DAY 20 | PRE-READ

When Nobody Knows Exactly What Is Wrong

A light read before Day 20. About 15 minutes.

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Why read this?

Real customer problems rarely arrive neatly described. People say "it is slow", "the numbers are wrong" or "we need AI". Tomorrow you practise turning that fog into a clear problem, finding the real cause, and working well inside a customer's organisation.

1. Ambiguity is normal

A doctor rarely hears "I have a vitamin deficiency". They hear "I feel tired all the time". Good doctors ask questions, run a few tests, and narrow it down. FDEs do the same with business problems. Being comfortable not knowing, while steadily finding out, is a core skill.

2. Asking why, five times

If your car will not start, "the battery is flat" is the first answer. But why is it flat? The lights were left on. Why? There is no warning sound. Fixing the warning sound stops it happening again. Asking **why** repeatedly moves you from the symptom to the real cause.

3. Guess, then check

Detectives do not wait for a confession. They form a theory, look for evidence, and change the theory if the evidence disagrees. This is **hypothesis-driven problem solving**, and tomorrow you will do it with real-looking data.

> **Key idea:** opinions start the conversation; evidence ends it.

4. Working inside someone else's organisation

Person	What they usually care about
The sponsor who hired you	Results, cost and deadlines
The daily users	Whether their day gets easier
IT and platform teams	That nothing breaks
Security and compliance	That data is protected and rules are followed

Each group sees the same problem differently. Talking to all of them early avoids nasty surprises later.

5. Keeping the work the right size

Projects grow if every "can you also..." is accepted. Good FDEs agree a small first version, keep a visible list of extra requests, and discuss trade-offs openly: "Yes, we can add that. Which other item should move to make room?"

6. Think about these before class

- Recall a vague request you received at work. What questions would have clarified it?
- Pick a recurring problem in your life and ask why five times.
- Think of a project that grew too big. What would have kept it on track?

Naze naze bunseki (なぜなぜ分析): why-why analysis, asking why repeatedly to find the root cause